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BUT IS IT ENOUGH? New recruits pose with the PM's cutout at the Rozgar Mela in Patna, Jan. 20

Early in her speech, Sitharaman outlined three imperatives for the economic agenda her budget had to deal with. The first was "providing a strong impetus for growth and job creation". The second added to the first by "facilitating ample opportunities for citizens, especially the youth, to fulfil their aspirations". The third was to achieve growth by keeping the fiscal deficit to manageable levels and "strengthening macroeconomic stability". It was by no means an easy job. However, backed by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, the finance minister announced a massive boost in capital expenditure, setting aside Rs 10 lakh crore, a 33 per cent increase from 2022-23. Railways and roads, transport and highways were given huge allocations too, with their outlays seeing an increase of 48 per cent and 24.4 per cent, respectively. Allocation to the government housing scheme PM Awas Yojana also saw an increase of 66 per cent in outlay. A clutch of incentives followed for other key employment-generating sectors, such as tourism, and MSMEs (micro, small and medium enterprises).

The Modi government came in for much praise for presenting a budget that pushed for faster growth through increased capex and slashing taxes while maintaining fiscal prudence. Kumar Mangalam Birla, chairman of the Aditya Birla Group, said, "The finance minister has once again done a stellar job of supporting growth while maintaining fiscal pragmatism. That too at a time when most advanced economies are wrestling with recessionary conditions." However, Sitharaman's feelgood budget, which had something for everyone, will finally be judged on how much these measures will ease unemployment, which has reached alarming proportions for the young, especially with the pandemic-induced attrition across sectors. The current Periodic Labour Force Survey (PLFS) of the Union labour ministry in September 2022 pegged the overall unemployment rate at 7.2 per cent, down from 9.8 per cent in September 2021 at the height of the pandemic. But while the government can claim credit for bringing down the unemployment rate, the real issue is that it remains high in the 20-29-year age group, which makes up close to a fifth of India's total workforce.



"THE Rs 10 LAKH CR. CAPEX BY THE CENTRE AND THE Rs 3.7 LAKH CR. GRANT-IN-AID TO STATES WILL ADD UP TO 4.5% OF GDP. THIS WILL BE A BIG JOB CREATOR"

—VINAYAK CHATTERJEE
Chairman, Feedback Infra

THE REAL PAIN POINT

In December 2022, the Centre for Monitoring Indian Economy (CMIE) data showed that the unemployment rate rose to 48 per cent for those in the 20-24 age bracket (more than double the 20 per cent in 2017-18 and higher than the 30 per cent just before the pandemic) and 14 per cent for the 25-29 age group. In comparison, unemployment rate in the US among the 20-24 age group was 7.3 per cent in December 2022 and 3.5 per cent overall. In China, unemployment in the 16-24 age group stood at 16.7 per cent in December. However, what makes the situation worse in India is the problem of disguised employment, as many opt for ill-paying fall-back jobs till they get the ones that they are qualified for.

Kuldeep Narayan Tripathi, 24, a resident of Indira Nagar in Lucknow, knows that wait could be long. On budget day, he was busy laying out his